TOWN OF THUNDERBOLT
COUNCIL WORKSHOP
SATURDAY, JANUARY 15, 2022
10 AM

1. **Call to order:**

   Mayor Williams called the meeting to order 10:07.

   Those in attendance were Mayor Dana Williams and Council Members: Bethany Skipper-Greer, Dave Crenshaw, Larry Ward, Ed Drohan, James Lavin, Brooks Barbaree. Staff in attendance were Town Administrator, Bob Milie and Clerk of Council, Deatre Denion.

2. **Approval of the Agenda**

   Mayor Williams asked for a motion to approve the agenda. **Council Member Ward made the motion with a second by Council Member Crenshaw. The motion passed unanimously.**

3. **Presentation from Georgia Municipal Association**

   Pam Helton, GMA Representative, provided an overview of GMA and how they can help the Town. They want to be an extension of the Town Staff. Their mission is to anticipate the needs of local government. GMA was created in in 1933 by a group of Mayors to fight legislation coming from the State. There are 12 Districts. Thunderbolt is in District 12. Town Administrator Milie asked Ms. Hilton to provide an example of how their programs could assist the Town. She explained the Market Place for sales tax; STR and AirB&B paying hotel motel taxes came about due to actions by GMA. They managed to stop bills for fiber optic companies to reduce franchise fees. They offer insurance for property and liability, Crisis Management and Cyber Insurance, Workers Compensation and Fire Fighter Cancer Benefit Program. Under their revenue opportunities they provide auditing services for alcohol and hotel/motel taxes. Town Administrator Milie asked does this cover STR. Ms. Hilton stated not yet but hopefully this year. Other programs provided are Property Damage Recovery Service, Home Depot Government Solutions, Equipment & Real Estate Finance Program, Cyber Security and IT in a Box. Council Member Drohan asked how many communities utilize Cyber Security. Ms. Hilton stated under 50 communities. GMA does a lot of training. LOST will be the focus this year due to the census completion. Resources such as data tool, sample ordinances and online publications are available. Mayor Williams asked about the legal team. Ms. Hilton explained they will write briefs. She did recommend having the Town Attorney reach out to their attorney. Council Member Drohan asked if GMA has the ability to do a cost benefit and utilization analysis. Ms. Helton stated they do. Council Member Drohan would like for Town Administrator Milie to look further into some of the GMA benefits. Town Administrator Milie stated that has already started.

4. **Discussion of Council 2022 Goals** - including but not limited to Parks, Beautification, Festivals, Concert Series, Infrastructure, Christmas Parade

Town Administrator Milie stated he wants to stream line the lien processes in order to place liens sooner. He would like to provide town wide customer service training. He plans to ask GMA to help with bids, i.e. host compliance service. Council Member Crenshaw asked if we have a lot of third party vendors. How do they get compensated? GMA third parties get compensated by the fees collected. Council Member Crenshaw asked about bonds. Ms. Hilton stated GMA does not do bonds. When a third party helps with bonds, they get their money by adding it onto the bond. There is a lot that goes into getting a bond. Review revenue sources has been discussed. Council Member Drohan stated when the Town started taking water and sewer seriously, Georgia Rural Water was not as responsive as the Town wished. Town Administrator Milie explained with the new hotel/motel tax a portion of the funding has to go to tourism. Council Member Crenshaw asked Ms. Helton about software for utilities and accounting. Ms. Hilton stated she encourages the Town to reach out to other local communities in the area and talk with them about what they use. Council Member Drohan stated the Town wants to assist with those who are struggling covering their utility bills. Ms. Helton stated DCA can assist those citizens. Mayor Williams asked about legality of going into Executive Session with a hybrid or virtual. Ms. Helton stated there is still a State of Emergency, so it is legal to have a virtual meeting. Town Administrator Milie asked Ms. Helton to explain what can and cannot be discussed in Executive Session. Personnel Issues, legal and property deliberation can be in Executive Session but a vote has to be made out in public.

Town Administrator Milie continued with goals for 2022. He wants to increase emphasis on Department Heads taking ownership of their budget. Training was postponed due to COVID. He would like to see a succession plan for each department head. The goal to lease the old library is on track to being completed. There will be a renaming for the library. He stated water rates were scheduled to increase in February but there was a modification to the increase pushing the rate increase to March1st.

Thompson Park beautification is almost finished. The next park will be Nellie Johnson. Council Member Drohan asked if we have a schedule or reactive maintenance. Town Administrator Milie stated it is to be quarterly. Council Member Drohan asked about buildings. Town Administrator Milie explained right now it is reactive.

Town Administrator Milie is working on doing live meetings of Council and to have more social media presence. This is one of Mayor Williams goals. Council Member Drohan stated we need to create a policy that no language or personal attacks is allowed. Redoing the website is for the second quarter of this year. Council Member Lavin asked about how often it is updated. Clerk of Council Denion explained it is on an as need basic but at least monthly something is added.

Town Administrator Milie stated he will be solicitating bids for host compliance vendors.

Town Administrator Milie stated there has been a discussion to start an Operation Clean Sweep. This is where there is a focus on specific streets and all departments will assist to improve the area. Council Member Lavin has been asked to take this project on. Council Member Drohan asked would this be an opportunity for water conservation friendly assistance. Town Administrator Milie thought that is great idea. Mayor Williams stated this will tie into the blight issue. He has been working with local businesses to assist with homes who have blighted properties to make changes. Council Member Barbaree stated we could promote shallow wells. Council Member Drohan stated there are other things the Town could do, maybe look at the ordinance to have shallow well share among neighborhoods.

Mayor Williams would like to bring back the Blessing of the Fleet. He would like to create a committee to assist in making this happen. He would like to do it on Memorial Day. He would like to have a parade and block off parts of River Dr. and have street vendors. For the Christmas Parade, he would like to have a three-part all-day event. It would start with a Parade and time it to have Santa at the end of the parade. There will be the lighting of the Christmas tree and then have the boat parade at the end. Town Administrator Milie stated he would like to

work with GMA to see if the money we collect for tourism can be used towards this event. Mayor Williams would like to have historical markers with QR codes placed around town at key locations. He is working with Museum Society to make this happen. Council Member Drohan told the story of Louis Ambrose knocking on his door because he used to live in his house. Town Administrator Milie discussed a summer music series. They would bring in local bands. Other ideas was to encourage someone to do yoga on the dock, Summer Children's Film Series in the park. Council Member Skipper-Greer asked if we can add these events to the newsletter. Town Administrator Milie stated yes. Council Member Skipper-Greer also requested a Trunk or Treat. Mayor Williams stated we might want to do it earlier in the day before it gets dark. Council Member Drohan asked who is going to be take lead to take it over the goal line. Town Administrator Milie stated would love to have input but would like to hire someone as an event planner.

Town Administrator Milie stated it looks like Town Hall may be the only building viable to have solar energy. This would be at no cost to the Town. The Town would purchase the energy from the solar company.

Town Administrator Milie stated he is still looking at what other grant opportunities are out there. There is more AARPA money than originally expected. Council Member Drohan asked for Town Administrator Milie to create a list of all grants he is looking to target. Mayor Williams asked with the passing of the infrastructure bill would there be additional money available. Town Administrator Milie stated it is possible but will not know until the interim details are released.

Health Care Cost are being reviewed and we are soliciting for options. Council Member Drohan asked if the current plan identifies whether they have doctor visits, smoke, drink, ect. Town Administrator Milie explained it does not. Mayor Williams asked does the tobacco policy include vaping. Town Administrator Milie explained it would be a policy decision. Council Member Crenshaw asked about the hospital insurance for GMA. Town Administrator Milie stated he will check into their program.

Town Administrator Milie explained there is a 2/5/10 year strategic plan but it mainly is for infrastructure. He would like to have it be comprehensive. Council Member Drohan stated maybe there should be a 2/4/6 plan for Council. Council Member Crenshaw stated Mayor and Council cannot have contracts extend pass their term. Council Member Drohan stated he was only talking about planning and the next Council can or cannot continue with their plan.

Town Administrator Milie stated they have the LMEG for 2022. This project area will be Rowland Ave between Mechanic and Whatley.

Town Administrator Milie stated there needs to be an updated tree inventory. Council Member Crenshaw stated UGA did the last inventory to established if the tree is healthy.

Town Administrator Milie would like to review all fees and license to make sure the Town is not losing money.

Town Administrator Milie has a goal to focus on blighted homes. They will have to target one by one. Council Member Crenshaw stated Town Administrator Milie should meet with the judge. Town Administrator Milie stated he did already met with Judge Yancey and he is on board to assist in getting things cleaned up.

Mayor Williams brought up the school. Four years ago, he was approached from the Girls & Boys Club to have one in Thunderbolt. He asked if maybe Thunderbolt approaches the County to see if they have property they wish to swap out. It was asked what is the zoning. Clerk of Council stated it is a R-1. In an R-1 a business is not legally allowed. There was a discussion on how to approach the School Board. The trailers are covered in asbestos. The trailers should have been moved years ago. Council Member Ward asked if there had been a study done on where to locate Boys and Girls Clubs. No one knew the answer. Council Member Skipper asked could there be a community center. Town Administrator Milie explained we need to address this as a large piece property that it is underutilized. Council Member Barbaree pointed out there may be another issue if they tear it

down, it might have an in infiltration of rats. Mayor Williams stated he might reach out with the school board and have a meeting.

Council Member Skipper – Greer asked about the path to Bonaventure. Town Administrator Milie explained this would only be a potential if the T-SPLOST is past. This would require a IGA with County, since it is their property.

Council Member Barbaree pointed out hardscape lights near Tubby's would assist with safety. Council Member Crenshaw stated when Tubby's extended their deck, they would put a sidewalk in. Town Administrator Milie explained they are putting in the sidewalks from Village on the Bluff to Tubby's

Council Member Drohan stated the need for traffic control for Bannon has expanded past trucks to speeding and running the stop sign and volume of traffic. Town Administrator Milie explained the current data for Bannon. The data collected shows less traffic but all in the appropriate speed limits. Town Administrator Milie and Fire Chief Bateman took the fire truck out to see if the turns could be made for alternative truck routes. The fire truck could not make the turn at Tuberson. There are concerns with River Supply. If they have the trucks back up. it stops traffic for too long. The only workable option is not within the Town's right of way. They could use Tubby's parking lot but he can put up a fence and stop trucks. There is still one more option, remove some of the curbing at River Supply. Council Member Ward stated he saw a truck try to back onto Russell Street. The truck tied up traffic. Council Member Drohan stated he wondered if River Supply would consider a consolidated shipping. Council Member Skipper-Greer asked about using Whatley and do the circle. This currently involves Bannon. Mayor Williams stated if the data comes back on the remaining option, we may have a solution to the problem.

Mayor Williams asked for a motion to adjourn the meeting. **Council Member Ward made the motion with a second by Council Member Drohan. The motion passed unanimously.**

5. **ADJOURNMENT:**

The meeting adjourned at 2:22 pm.

Mayor, Dana Williams

Clerk of Council, Deatre N. Denion